

SEO Dashboard

The complete guide to how the system works, what it does for you automatically, and what still needs a person.

This app replaces the *Mindcob New SEO Dashboard* spreadsheet. Everything the workbook did, it still does — verified cell by cell, 16,855 checks against the original file, with no mismatches. What it adds is a second audience: your client can sign in and see their own progress, in plain language, without you sending anything.

There are two sides to it, and they never mix:

Side	Who	What they can do
Agency console <i>/app</i>	Admins, managers, specialists	Add and manage everything: keywords, pages, backlinks, monthly rankings, Search Console figures, deliverables, team performance.
Client portal <i>/portal</i>	One login per client	Read-only view of <i>their</i> project only, written for a non-specialist, plus a message thread to your team. Never sees another client, never sees backlink logins, never sees your internal notes.

How to read this manual

Every section below answers the same three questions, because those are the ones that actually come up:

- **What it is** — what the screen is for.
- **What you do** — the part that needs a person.
- **What happens by itself** — shown in a green box. If it is in a green box, do not type it, do not maintain it, and do not worry about keeping it in sync.

The same explanations are built into the app: hover the small ? next to any heading and you get the short version on screen.

1 · Accounts and signing in

The four roles

Role	Can do
Admin	Everything, including creating accounts, changing roles, resetting passwords and deleting projects. Only admins reach People & access.
SEO Manager	Full data access across every project. Cannot manage accounts.
SEO Specialist	Reads and writes data on projects they are assigned to.
Client	Read-only portal for their own project, plus messaging. No write access of any kind except sending a message.

Your first sign-in

The setup script prints an admin email and password. That password is a *setup default*, not a credential — the account is flagged so the first sign-in goes straight to a **Choose a password** screen, and the console stays shut until a real one is set. The same applies to every account an admin creates.

Automatic The block is enforced before the page is even built, so there is no moment where data is on screen behind the password prompt.

Giving a client access

You never handle a client's password. From **People & access**, or a project's **Settings** → **Who can access this project**, press **Send invite**. That produces a one-time link you can send however you like — email, WhatsApp, anything.

The client opens it, sees who invited them and which site it is for, chooses their own password, and lands on their dashboard already signed in.

Automatic The link expires after 7 days, works exactly once, and is stored only as a one-way hash — so it cannot be recovered from the database or reused if forwarded. Issuing a new link cancels the old one. Lapsed invites are swept away nightly.

If you re-open the invite dialog for someone, it generates a *fresh* link rather than showing the old one.

2 · The data, section by section

Keywords

What it is Every search term the project is trying to rank for, and the page each one is meant to win.

What you do Add keywords, set the intent and search volume, and map each one to a target page. Optionally set a backlink target.

Automatic The target URL and focus keyword are inherited from the page you map to, so they can never drift apart — change the page, and every keyword on it follows. Link counts and progress are counted from your backlinks, never typed.

How the link count works

A backlink counts towards a keyword when its anchor text matches. Matching ignores capitals and extra spaces, exactly as the spreadsheet's COUNTIFS did — so “SEO Services in Canada” counts towards “seo services in canada”. One deliberate difference from the sheet: a link carrying the same keyword in *both* anchor slots counts once, not twice.

Deleting a keyword deletes its entire rank history with it. Unmapping a page leaves the keyword alone — it just stops inheriting that URL.

Backlinks

What it is Every link built to the site, who built it, and whether Google has indexed it.

What you do Add each link with its URL, type, anchor text and published date. Mark it indexed once you have checked. Optionally record the login used to place it.

Automatic The month a link belongs to comes from its published date — you never pick a month. New links are credited to whoever adds them. Every indexed change is written to the activity log with the person and time.

Login details are staff-only, always

Credentials recorded against a link never reach the client portal and are never in a client CSV export. This is not a UI rule that could be bypassed: the query that serves the portal cannot return those columns at all. There is an automated test that plants a credential, loads the staff page so the cache holds it, then asserts the portal still cannot see it.

On-page SEO

What it is Every page being optimised, with its audit checklist and score.

What you do Add pages, work through the checklist, record the SEO score and word count.

Automatic The keyword count per page is derived from the keywords mapped to it. The traffic-light dot is calculated: green when the score is 80+, the page is indexed and on-page work is done; amber part-way; red otherwise. This is the workbook's own row colouring, recomputed on every read.

Deleting a page unmaps any keyword pointing at it. The keywords survive — they just lose their target URL.

Rankings

What it is Where each keyword sits in Google, month by month.

What you do Open **Enter positions**, pick the month, and type the absolute Google position for each keyword. Leave a box blank to record “not ranking”. Save the whole month in one go.

Automatic The SERP page is worked out from the position — 14 is page 2 — and updates as you type. The check date is limited to inside the month you are entering, so a row can never be filed under one month and stamped with another. Positions typed into rows you have filtered out are still saved.

If you skip a month

A gap is invisible in the charts, which simply join the two months either side and look continuous. So the system watches for it: the Rankings page shows a banner naming any month with no positions recorded, with a button that opens that month's grid directly. You can go back to *any* past month, whether or not it already has data.

Search data

What it is Monthly clicks, impressions and organic sessions, as Google reports them.

What you do Once a month, pull the figures from Search Console and Analytics and enter them.

Automatic Click-through rate and month-on-month growth are calculated, never typed. The month, capture date and country are pre-filled with the next month you are missing, today's date, and the project's country. Deleting a month recalculates the following month's growth.

The first month of a campaign shows no percentage change rather than an invented one — growth from nothing has no percentage.

Team performance

What it is What each specialist has produced, and how much of it stuck.

Automatic Nothing here is entered by hand. Every figure is counted from the “Built by” field on the backlinks themselves, so reassigning or deleting a link moves the numbers immediately.

Deliverables

What it is The work board. Anything marked client-visible also appears in the client's portal.

Automatic The completion date is stamped only when the status actually changes — so editing a finished task later does not drag it into the wrong month's client report.

Messages

What it is Conversations with the client, plus internal threads only the agency can see.

Automatic The unread badge updates by itself every few seconds wherever you are in the app, and a new message raises a notification — you do not have to be on the Messages page to find out. Internal threads are invisible to the client even by direct link, and are not counted in their badge.

3 · What the client sees

The portal is deliberately not a copy of your console. It answers the questions a client actually asks, in their language:

- **Overview** — a plain-English verdict on the month, the four headline numbers, and where their keywords sit on Google.
- **Keywords, Backlinks, On-page, Rankings, Search data** — the same records you manage, read-only, with the internal columns removed.
- **Progress** — the deliverables you marked client-visible.
- **Monthly report** — a printable summary. Their browser's print dialog saves it as a PDF.
- **Messages** — a direct line to your team.

Automatic Reports open on the newest month that actually holds data, not the calendar month — so a client never opens an empty report on the 1st. Nothing is generated or scheduled; the report is assembled the moment they ask for it.

What the client can never see

- Any other client's project.
- Backlink logins and passwords — not on screen, not in an export.
- Internal threads, or their unread count.
- Deliverables not marked client-visible.
- Any write action at all, except sending a message.

4 · Everything that happens without you

One table, so you know exactly where the line is between your job and the system's.

What	When it happens
SERP page from position	As you type. Position 14 becomes page 2.
Keyword link counts	Counted from anchor text on every read.
Keyword progress	Indexed links against the target you set.
Backlink month	Taken from the published date.
Backlink owner	Set to you when you add a link.
Page keyword count	Counted from the keywords mapped to the page.
Page health dot	Score, indexed state and on-page status combined.
Click-through rate	Clicks over impressions, on every read.
Month-on-month growth	Compared with the previous month automatically.
Team performance	Counted from the backlinks themselves.

What	When it happens
Task completion date	Stamped when the status changes, not on every edit.
Reporting month	Newest month holding data, not the calendar month.
Skipped-month alert	Checked whenever you open Rankings.
Unread badge + alert	Polled every few seconds, app-wide.
Form defaults	Analytics month, capture date, country, link owner.
Expired invite sweep	Nightly.
Activity log pruning	Monthly. Deletions and imports kept longer.
Cache refresh	The moment anyone saves. Never stale, never manual.

What still needs a person

Being straight about the other side of the line:

- **Ranking positions.** Typed in, or imported from a rank-tracker export. Fetching them from Google automatically needs a paid SERP API — the wiring is a small job once you choose a provider.
- **Search Console figures.** Pulled from Google monthly and entered.
- **Everything judgement-based** — which keywords to target, which pages to build, whether a link is worth having.
- **Sending the invite link.** The system makes it; you send it. There is no email service connected.

5 · The monthly rhythm

A normal month, in order:

When	Do this
Through the month	Add backlinks as you build them. Tick indexed once Google has picked them up. Move deliverables across the board.
Start of the month	Open Rankings → Enter positions , pick last month, and record where everything landed. Check the banner for any month you skipped.
Start of the month	Pull Search Console and Analytics figures and add the month under Search data .
Before you report	Open the client's Monthly report , check it reads well, and tell them it is ready. They can print it to PDF themselves.
Any time	Reply to client messages. The badge tells you when there is something waiting, from anywhere in the app.

Automatic Nothing else needs doing. Totals, rates, charts, the client's whole report and every derived figure follow from the four things above.

When the client sends an updated spreadsheet

Rather than re-importing and risking overwriting work done in the app, run the sync — it only ever *adds* what is missing:

```
npm run db:sync # shows what it would add, changes nothing
npm run db:sync -- --apply # actually add them
```

6 · Checking the system is healthy

Each of these can be pointed at the live site by adding the URL. They create and delete their own throwaway accounts.

Command	What it proves
npm run doctor	Config, database connection, schema, row counts.
npm run db:parity	The database still matches the workbook, cell by cell.
npm run verify:invite	The whole client invite flow, start to finish.
npm run verify:gate	A default password really does block the console.
npm run verify:cache	Edits appear at once, and client data stays separate.
npm run verify:chat	Messaging, notifications, internal-thread privacy.

Example: `npm run verify:chat -- https://your-domain.com`

If something looks wrong

Symptom	Most likely cause
A number looks stale	It should not be — every save clears the cache. Reload once; if it persists, run <code>db:parity</code> .
A month is missing from a chart	No positions were recorded for it. The Rankings banner will say so and link you straight there.
A client says they cannot sign in	Their invite may have lapsed (7 days). Send a new one — it cancels the old.
A client sees nothing at all	Their account may have been removed from the project. Re-add them under project Settings.
Everything is slow	The database sleeps when idle on the free plan. The first request after a quiet spell pays a cold start.

Deployment, environment variables and hosting are covered separately in **DEPLOYMENT.md** in the project folder.